

Inside an Abuser's Mind: Control, Ent Ownership and Superiority



SHADOWS OF CONTROL

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Why does someone abuse the person they claim to love? It's a quest often wrestle with — not just to make sense of what happened, but they were really dealing with. The answer doesn't lie in anger, alcohol childhood trauma. Abuse is not caused by circumstances. It is drive

These attitudes form early — long before any particular relationship is embedded, often unconsciously, through years of socialisation, belief systems, family dynamics, and gender conditioning. By the time the abuser enters a relationship, these values are already operating under the surface. *A means* of asserting those attitudes, not a response to the relationship.

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To make sense of this abusive mindset, I've developed the **COERCION** lens to help unpack the psychology of coercive control and intimate terrorism. Each letter represents a core feature of the abuser's inner world:

C – Control

O – Ownership

E – Entitlement

R – Righteousness

C – Competitiveness

E – Enmeshment

S– Superiority

These beliefs form the root system of coercive control — a dynamic in cycles of fear, guilt, and confusion.

C – Control

In an intimate relationship, decisions, needs, and boundaries are not the abuser's, relationships are not collaborative — they are hierarchical, an occasional tactic; it is the foundation.

This deep-rooted belief in the *right* to control means they feel entitled where their partner goes, who they speak to, how they spend their time, wear, and even how they think. It's a mindset that sees freedom as a compromise as weakness.

Abusers don't lose control – they set out to establish it and then maintain it. If it slips, the abuser believes they are justified in using manipulation and violence to restore their dominance.

O – Ownership

At the core of the abusive mindset is a belief in *ownership* — the idea that if someone is in a relationship with them, that person becomes theirs to define. This is not about emotional closeness or deepening intimacy.

possession. The partner is not viewed as a separate human being with their own needs, but as an object whose role is to reflect, serve, or elevate the abuser's needs. This belief is often cloaked in language that sounds like love: “You’re mine,” or “I can’t live without you.” But underneath the romantic facade is a mindset that sees the partner as something to be claimed.

As the relationship progresses, this sense of ownership tends to intensify. Commitment is interpreted as a form of acquisition — a justification for more intrusion, and more punishment when the partner resists. Rather than mutual respect over time, the abuser tightens their grip. The more they believe they have the *right* to define how the relationship should be, the more they believe they have the *right* to define how the relationship should be, regardless of how their partner feels.

E – Entitlement

Entitlement is one of the most defining features of the abusive mindset. It is the belief that *their* needs, desires, opinions, and preferences matter more than anyone else's. This belief often leads to a sense of superiority and a lack of empathy for others.

This belief shows up in many ways: double standards, emotional manipulation, and retaliation when boundaries are set. The abuser expects special treatment and accommodation from their partner, without offering the same in return. They demand attention, support, and admiration — yet show little empathy for their partner's emotional life.

This isn't situational. It comes from the ingrained belief: "I come first, I meet my needs." And when that expectation isn't met, punishment — emotional, psychological, or physical — often follows.

R – Righteousness

Abusers don't usually see themselves as cruel or unjust. Instead, they see themselves as *justified*. That is the danger of righteousness. It provides moral cover for abusive behaviour.

When the abusive partner acts out — whether by yelling, isolating, degrading — they may feel completely justified in doing so. They may be "correcting" you, protecting you, or reacting to something *you* did wrong. It may seem twisted, but internally it feels consistent: "If I'm angry, it must be because you wronged me. If I punish you, it's because you deserve it."

This sense of moral superiority makes accountability nearly impossible. It creates confusion for the victim, who is often manipulated into believing that the abuse is somehow their fault.

C – Competitiveness

Rather than seeking mutual understanding, the abuser treats relationships as a win-lose contest. There must be a winner and a loser — and they refuse to back down.

This competitive mindset plays out in subtle and overt ways. In arguments, they aim to dominate rather than discuss. In disagreements, they aim to silence. During calm periods, there is often a quiet undercurrent of one-upmanship or scorekeeping. Everything becomes a measure of who holds more influence, more control.

This adversarial attitude doesn't fade when the relationship ends — it intensifies. If their partner leaves, the abuser may see it not as a separation but as a challenge to their authority. They may become determined to win, to defeat their ex in court, to secure the better financial outcome, to mislead friends with false narratives. If children are involved, they may use them not just to cause pain, but to maintain a position of dominance. They may manipulate the child's affection, undermine the safe parent, or twist the child's perception of what happened. The abuser has a relentless need to come out on top, no matter the cost or hurt in the process.

E – Enmeshment

A key feature of the abusive mindset is the refusal to acknowledge the partner as a separate, autonomous person. In this worldview, the partner is not seen as having a distinct emotional life, independent thoughts, or personal boundaries. The partner is expected to mirror the abuser's needs, beliefs, moods, and interests at all times.

The abuser does not see their partner as a separate person — they see them as an extension of themselves.

extension of themselves. This mindset is driven by a deep expectation of sameness: the partner should think what they think, feel what they feel, want what they want. Any difference is treated as disobedience, and any attempt to create a separate reality is dismissed as irrational, selfish, or wrong.

Over time, this erasure of individuality leads the victim to second-guess themselves and suppress their inner world, not out of weakness but as a survival strategy. An enmeshing mindset leaves no room for autonomy — only compliance and emotional absorption into the self of the one who demands control.

S – Superiority

At the core of the abusive mindset lies a deep belief in personal superiority. Abusers see themselves as more rational, more intelligent, more capable, and more in control. They believe their judgement is better. Their needs are always right.

This isn't just arrogance. It's a psychological stance that justifies even the most severe abuse. It explains why they interrupt, talk over, belittle, or dismiss their partner, and also why they often have little empathy for the harm they cause.

To them, the relationship is not between equals. It's a hierarchy — with them at the top.

Abuse Is Not a Loss of Control — It's a Illusion of Control

Belief

To understand the abusive mindset, it's important to be clear about what it is. It is not the result of momentary loss of control, a drinking problem, or external pressures. Abusers often function calmly in other areas of life. They exhibit abusive behaviour at work, with friends, or around authority figures — because they believe they have the right to control those people.

Their abusive behaviour is selective and strategic. It appears in intimate relationships because that's where they feel most entitled to power.

This is why explanations based on external factors fall short. Stress and trauma may shape personality, but neither creates a mindset built on entitlement, ownership, and superiority. These beliefs are absorbed over time, often before a relationship begins. The partner is never the cause of the abuse — it's the path of a system that was already in place.

The Core of the Problem

The COERCES framework reveals the underlying architecture of abuse, not just what abusers *do*, but what they *believe*. These are not momentary lapses or reactions. They are part of a broader system of values that prioritises control, denies equality, and devalues the victim.

For survivors, understanding this can bring clarity. It shifts the focus from blaming the abuser to understanding the system that enabled the abuse.

do wrong?” to “What was already there before I even entered the picture?” For professionals and advocates, it helps explain why abuse doesn’t end with an apology or a change in circumstances — because what needs to change is the foundation. It will not be resolved through better communication, conflict resolution, meditation, or anger management classes, because the problem is not communication and it is not miscommunication or poor emotional regulation — it is a mindset rooted in domination.

The most dangerous part of abuse is not the outburst, but the belief system that justifies it. Until that belief system is addressed, the pattern will continue. Recognition is the first step toward breaking the cycle.

Featured image: The abusive mindset. Source: [Serhii Holdin](#) / Adobe

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Christina Jul 17

♥ Liked by Shadows of Control

Wow... this is one of the most direct, comprehensive articles I've read, misperceptions that I see in the past led to false hope. It's not just the because at work, he acted different. It's not just learning to manage his mention if that were the root problem, it would be with everyone, in all He's choosing to abuse and to manipulate where it serves his best inte the ability to do so via control and a lack of firm boundaries - mic drop